Walk calibration of BTL modules in testbeam:

Via Synchronization of MCP scope data with FEBd

CMS

cms-dpg-conveners-mtd@cern.ch

Discussion draft; not approved for public release.

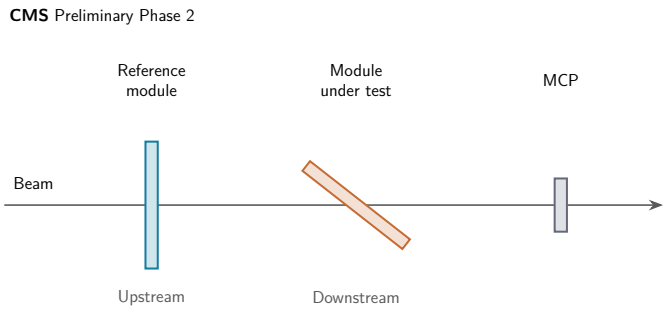
Abstract

Several analyses of the 2025 CMS barrel timing layer (BTL) test-beam data benefit from a reliable particle-arrival time reference. A Hamamatsu microchannel-plate photomultiplier (MCP-PMT), digitized by a digital oscilloscope, provides an external reference for a subset of the data. Its limited acceptance and acquisition rate motivate transferring the timing calibration to a BTL reference module.

A trigger link through the FEBd readout correlates events in the two streams. Clock alignment and locally weighted smoothing correct their low-frequency relative drift. Quadratic functions of inverse charge then describe the time walk of the left and right channels of a bar.

The calibrated reference bar provides a time reference for BTL analyses. The time difference between a bar in the module under test and the reference bar, before and after walk correction, tests the calibration. This FEBd-based synchronization procedure is specific to the test-beam setup.

Parallel MCP and BTL streams are linked through FEBd



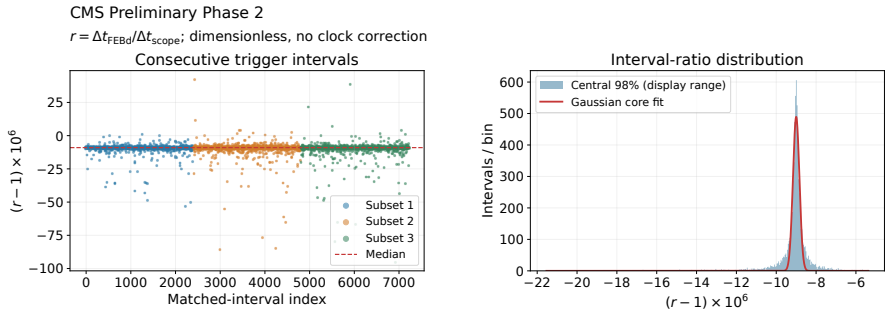
Two readout streams
The scope records the MCP-PMT pulse. FEBd records the BTL SiPM signals.

Synchronization link
The scope trigger also reaches a dedicated TOFHIR trigger channel in FEBd.
This link connects independently clocked records of the same particle.

September 2025 beam test, top view (not to scale). The reference module is perpendicular to the beam; the module under test is tilted. The MCP is downstream of both modules. This FEBd-based synchronization is specific to the test-beam setup, not the final HL-LHC synchronization scheme.

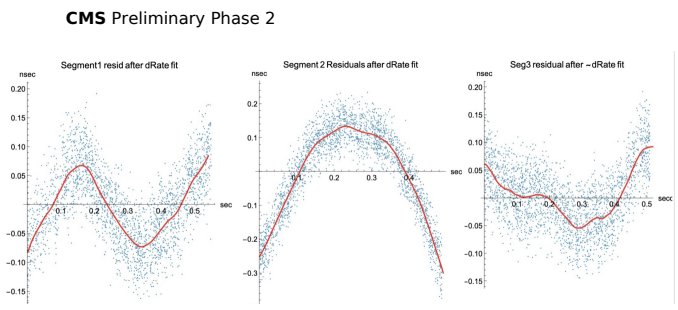
Events are correlated using the intervals between triggers

Match consecutive trigger-interval patterns in FEBd and the scope; retain unique event pairs.



Colors identify dataset subsets (segments). Δt is the interval between consecutive matched triggers within a subset. Scatter: all 7,203 intervals; histogram: central 98%. Axes show $(r-1)\times 10^6$, a dimensionless quantity. Gaussian fit window: median $\pm 1.5(1.4826\,\mathrm{MAD})$; its width measures ratio spread, not intrinsic timing noise. The next slide examines slow drift using time residuals after linear alignment. GitHub: trigger matching.

The matched clocks show low-frequency relative drift



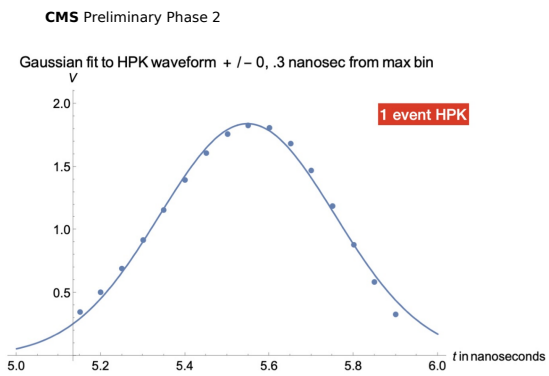
Correct the timing coordinate

1. Split data at clock resets.
2. Fit a line between matched trigger times in each segment.
3. Fit the remaining drift with LOWESS.

Add the drift to the line prediction to obtain $g(u)$, the expected TOFHIR trigger time.

Points show residuals before LOWESS; red curves describe smooth drift. Reject groups with pre-LOWESS residual scale $1.4826\,\mathrm{MAD} > 1$ ns. GitHub: clock reconstruction.

After synchronization, the MCP defines the calibration time



Fit the MCP waveform to estimate its pulse time.
Within the scope waveform, define

$$\delta_{\mathrm{MCP}} = t_{\mathrm{peak}} - t_{\mathrm{trigger}}.$$

For SiPM channel i, use

$$\Delta t_i = t_i - g(u) - \delta_{\mathrm{MCP}}.$$

The charge-dependent part of this difference is the walk.

The waveform and fitted template determine the MCP pulse time. u is the scope-trigger timestamp. A fixed cable/geometry offset is irrelevant to the shape; clock-rate conversion over the short waveform interval is neglected.

Measure the reference-module channels' time walk versus charge

Separate threshold settings before selection and fitting.

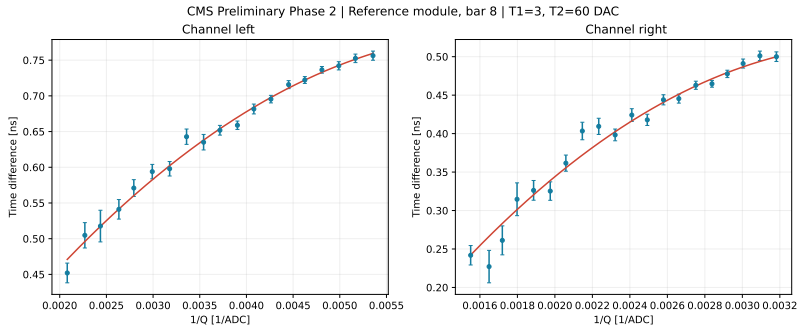
1. Require exactly five TOFHIR hits and a unique MCP match: the left and right channels of one bar in the reference module and one bar in the module under test, plus the dedicated trigger channel.
2. Within each setting, require clock quality and finite positive charge, ΔI and threshold-rise time. Keep charge above the spectrum's left half-maximum boundary.
3. Form 20 uniform $1/Q$ bins. Clip timing outliers at $5(1.4826\,\mathrm{MAD})$ from each bin's median; require at least five entries.
4. Fit the bin means with weights $1/\mathrm{SEM}^2$:

$$W_i(Q) = a_i + b_i/Q + c_i/Q^2.$$

Q is the measured ADC charge proxy, not energy in MeV. SEM denotes the standard error of the mean.

Reference module: bar 8; module under test: bar 3. Combine files only at identical scan settings. GitHub: selected reference sample.

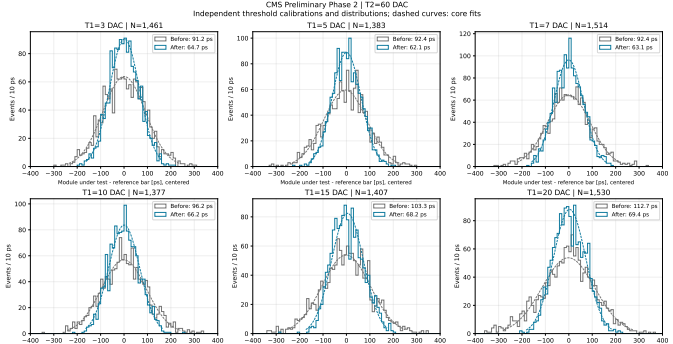
The walk-corrected reference bar provides the time reference



Correct each end: $t_i^{\mathrm{corr}} = t_i - W_i(Q_i)$. Use the bar average: $t_{\mathrm{ref}} = (t_L^{\mathrm{corr}} + t_R^{\mathrm{corr}})/2$.

Reference module, bar 8: left and right channels at $T_1 = 3$, $T_2 = 60$ (lowest scanned DAC setting). Points show profile means with SEM; curves are SEM-weighted quadratics in $1/Q$. The $+26$ ns display offset does not change the shape. Separate fits are made for every setting and all four channels.

Final result: module-under-test bar minus reference bar



Difference of bar-average times: module under test (bar 3) minus reference module (bar 8). Corrected core widths: 62–69 ps. For independent timing fluctuations, $\sigma_{\Delta t} = \sqrt{\sigma_{\mathrm{ref}}^2 + \sigma_{\mathrm{test}}^2} \approx 65\,\mathrm{ps}$; individual widths are not separately measured. Thresholds are fitted separately with identical before/after events. Display-only median centering; no per-file offsets. Dashed curves: truncated-normal fits within median $\pm 2.5(1.4826\,\mathrm{MAD})$. In-sample validation.

References

[1] GitHub repository, `https://github.com/De-Cristo/LecroyTranslator4CMSTimingDetector`.

[2] Presentation by the Saclay group. `https://indico.cern.ch/event/1619706/`

[3] "Timing Performance of a Micro-Channel-Plate Photomultiplier Tube", `https://arxiv.org/pdf/1909.12604`

[4] CMS Collaboration, "A MIP Timing Detector for the CMS Phase-2 Upgrade". Technical Report CERN-LHCC-2019-003. CMS-TDR-020, CERN, Geneva, 2019 and "A High-Granularity Timing Detector for the ATLAS Phase-II Upgrade", CERN-LHCC-2020-007; ATLAS-TDR-031

[5] S. White, Nov. 2025 BTL TB Analysis mtg presentation, `https://indico.cern.ch/event/1614521/contributions/6803723/attachments/3178820/5922530/5vs10vs20GSa_s.pdf`

[6] W. R. Leo, "Techniques For Nuclear and Particle Physics Experiments", p.326, Springer-Verlag Berlin Heidelberg.

[7] S. White and A. Boletti, "Amplitude Walk in Fast Timing: The Role of Dual Thresholds" 2026 JINST V21 P02001.

[8] W. S. Cleveland, "Robust Locally Weighted Regression and Regression Scatterplots", J. Amer. Statist. Assoc. **74** (1979) 829.